

BANKING ON INCLUSIVITY

For Axis Bank, the key to its success lies in building an inclusive culture, whether it be for employees or for its clients

By Ashish Rukhaiyar

FOR AXIS BANK, acquiring the consumer business—loans, credit cards, wealth management and retail banking—of Citi India was a big win as it positioned the country's third-largest private sector bank (in terms of total assets) for accelerated growth in the premium segment. Axis Bank reported total income of ₹82,597 crore in FY22.

72 | However, the ₹11,603-crore buy—that Axis Bank completed on March 1, 2023—also meant integrating around 3,200 people into the lender, which already had more than 88,000 employees on its rolls. And that wasn't the only challenge for the bank's HR—it also had to deal with the cultural differences that typically exist between a domestic entity and a foreign one. "In any integration, we need to recognise that as much as it is about embracing the others, it is also about managing our own people... So, the entire process was collaborative," says Rajkamal Vempati, Head of HR at Axis Bank.

For her team, the integration meant longer-than-normal working

hours for more than a few weeks. But they had an ally—technology. This ensured that the on-boarding of Citi employees—around 97 per cent of the Citi consumer business staffers came on board—was as seamless as possible. The highlight was an app designed specifically for the process.

That says a lot about Axis Bank, which started operations back in 1994, and was promoted by government-owned entities such as Life Insurance Corporation, General Insurance Corporation, National Insurance Company, The New India Assurance Company, United India Insurance Company and the erstwhile UTI.

While integrating the former Citi employees is an ongoing journey involving town hall meetings, one-on-one interactions and even a "buddy" system wherein Axis Bank staffers who have had earlier stints at Citi help the new lot ease in, the domestic lender has ensured that its HR practices are in sync with the



7 **AXIS BANK** TOP ATTRIBUTES

- FAIR AND OBJECTIVE PROCESSES & POLICIES
- GROWTH AND LEARNING OPPORTUNITIES
- FLEXIBILITY AT WORK

◀ **PLAYING FAIR** Rajkamal Vempati, Head of Human Resources, Axis Bank